

The WD Passport was the best performer in the read test with 33.3 MBps, and the Iomega drive top scored with 27.1 in the write test.

SiSoft Sandra Pro Business 2007

For this synthetic test, we created a 32 GB NTFS partition on the drive. Very little variation was seen here: the drive index varied from the maximum of 29 for the WD Passport, to the minimum of 25 for the Seagate. Access times varied more, with the WD having the lowest (9 ms), while the Iomega and Seagate drives had 16 ms—these were the slowest.

Real-World Tests: File copy

Since there was not a pronounced difference in the scores of the drives in the read and write tests in the assorted as well as the sequential file transfer tests, we move on to the intra-drive transfer tests. The Iomega was the quickest here, clocking just 1 minute and 35 seconds for 1 GB; the slowest was the Seagate with a distant 1 minute and 56 seconds. In the sequential file intra-drive test, the Iomega and the WD were the fastest, taking just over a minute and a half, while the Seagate and Maxtor were neck and neck, with the slowest timings of around a minute and 51 seconds.

In the multitasking file transfer test, the WD was the fastest, and took just 92.89 seconds to complete the copying of 1 GB of assorted data. The Seagate took over two minutes for the same task, and its weakness in a multitasking scenario is thus apparent.

The Winners

The Western Digital My Book Essential packs in good value by providing a ruggedly-built 500 GB external drive at just Rs 8,300. The cost per MB works to the lowest of all the drives—just 1.62 paise. Even though it did not come with backup software, you can get one for just a little extra, and so this drive is worth every penny. It's therefore been adjudged the *Digit Best Buy Gold* winner in the Backup External Hard Drive segment.

The Maxtor OneTouch III Turbo Edition is large, at 1 TB; it provides you the option to configure its twin drives in RAID configuration—you can either opt for better speed and capacity or for data security via redundancy. The backup button makes it very convenient for you to take backups using the excellent EMC Retrospect software. This was the performance king in this category and that is the most important parameter here. This drive



Iomega Portable Hard Drive 80 GB
Sleek portability

has got a wealth of features and performance and therefore bags the *Digit Best Buy Silver*. We chose this one over the others for the Silver award because even though it's expensive, at Rs 36,200, it's great if you're looking for sheer performance.

The Western Digital Passport Portable costs a tad bit higher (at Rs 6,500) than the others, but with 160 GB, boasted of the largest capacity. This gives it a very good cost per MB of just 3.97 paise—the best in this category. With excellent performance and coming with the WD Sync backup and synchronising software, this drive won the *Digit Best Buy Gold* award in the Portable External Hard Drive category.

The Iomega Portable Hard Drive was the lowest-priced drive in the portable segment. Its sleekness and lightness made it the most portable of all the drives. The EMC Retrospect backup software fetched it brownie points. With good performance in addition to all this, the Iomega Portable Hard Drive secures the *Digit Best Buy Silver*.

Closing Thoughts

The future is SATA all the way. With optical drives featuring SATA making a presence in the Indian market, the only reason for IDE to be still around is beginning to disappear. SATA 3.0 Gbps is already commonplace, and hot on its heels is SATA 6.0 Gbps. Not only will this new incarnation of SATA boast of superior bandwidth, it will also support connecting multiple drives to a single SATA port in conjunction with port multipliers.

SATA is already making its presence felt even in the external hard drive segment, thanks to External SATA or eSATA. Most external drives currently use the USB or FireWire interfaces that make use of PATA or SATA drives and bridges to translate between the drive's interface and the external ports. This bridging brings in some inefficiency. To get over this and increase data throughput, eSATA seems a viable solution.

This lets external hard drives achieve throughputs as high as their internal counterparts. eSATA requires motherboards with eSATA ports, and this is still fairly uncommon. But if a motherboard does not come with an eSATA port, it can still be upgraded by installing an eSATA Host Adapter Bus (HBA). Though this is definitely the next big thing in external storage, it is likely that it will remain alongside USB and FireWire.

We've tried hard to present all the possible purchase options available today, and we hope you're now in a position to make a better purchase decision. Though prices will always fall, you can't keep putting off a purchase just for that reason, can you? ☒

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